

Beak area away from the border. Amnesty International welcomes this relocation. There is still an urgent need, however, to relocate Liberian refugees in the areas around Macenta and Nzérékoré to safe areas.

Liberia

Human rights abuses in Liberia have dramatically increased since 1999 when Liberian armed political groups based in Guinea, believed to be backed by Guinean security forces, began incursions into Lofa County, northern Liberia. Diplomatic relations between Liberia and neighbouring Guinea and Sierra Leone progressively deteriorated. The Amnesty International delegation that visited Liberia in February 2001 found that scores of civilians suspected of supporting or collaborating with dissidents have been arrested, tortured and extrajudicially executed by Liberian security forces. It appears that women and girls have been raped by both government forces and armed political groups, although the identity of those responsible has often been difficult to establish. Civilians are reported to have been abducted by armed political groups. Some have been killed while trying to escape abduction. In an attempt to prevent sensitive information getting out of Liberia, especially about human rights abuses, critics and opponents of the government have frequently been labelled as "dissidents" by the authorities and have increasingly been subjected to verbal and physical attacks by the security forces.

Since February 2001 fighting in Lofa County has further intensified and Amnesty International has received reports of increasing human rights abuses against civilians, including internally displaced people. On 13 June 2001 the World Food Programme estimated the number of recently displaced people from Lofa Country to be around 40,000. Many people fleeing their homes have reportedly been turned back at checkpoints by the security forces on suspicion that dissidents were among them. Humanitarian agencies have frequently been denied access to internally displaced people or intimidated and threatened by the security forces while providing assistance or transferring displaced people. Camps for the internally displaced have been established in locations which many observers in Liberia believe to be too close to the areas affected by fighting. The strong presence in the camps of security forces responsible for human rights violations, such as the Anti-Terrorist Unit, has been a cause of concern for many civilians and humanitarian agencies.

The Liberian security forces have reportedly continued to recruit child soldiers, including from among internally displaced people. There have also been reports of people being subjected to beatings or torture by government forces when they have resisted recruitment. During 2000 the RUF reportedly carried out recruitment in camps for Sierra Leonean refugees in Liberia, including of former child soldiers who had previously been recruited by the RUF in Sierra Leone. Senior Liberian government officials were reportedly seen accompanying RUF personnel during the recruitment in refugee camps.

In some cases, Liberian refugees repatriated from Guinea have been arrested and tortured by Liberian security forces. On 14 June 2000 at least seven Liberian refugees from the Mandingo ethnic group, who had been repatriated from Guinea by UNHCR, were arrested by Liberian security forces at the Ganta border post, Nimba County. They were detained and tortured for two weeks and at least one of them reportedly died in custody.

There are no signs that the situation in northern Liberia will improve in the near future. The number of newly displaced people is likely to continue to increase. The UN Secretary-General, in his report of 23 May 2001, stated his deep concern that "the present fighting will result in tens of thousands of refugees and internally displaced persons to whom aid agencies would have no access" (paragraph 6). It is clear that refugees returning to Liberia now would be at serious risk of human rights violations and that no one should therefore be forced or encouraged to return.

Sierra Leone

By early June 2001 more than 55,000 Sierra Leonean refugees in Guinea had risked spontaneously returning to Sierra Leone; others are still returning. UNHCR has not promoted return to Sierra Leone because conditions are not yet conducive for repatriation. However, faced with very large numbers of refugees wishing to return, UNHCR has adopted a policy of facilitating that return. Around 35,000 refugees have returned by boat, assisted by UNHCR and the International Organization for Migration (IOM), an intergovernmental organization. As most of these refugees were originally from areas in northern and eastern Sierra Leone still under the control of the RUF, they are being resettled in areas in the west and south of the country.

At least 20,000 refugees have returned on foot from Guinea through RUF-held areas. Having been victims of attacks by armed political groups, Guinean security forces and Guinean civilians, many of those crossing the border into Kono and Kailahun Districts in eastern Sierra Leone have faced further abuse from the RUF. Women and girls have been raped, some of them abducted, and children have been forcibly recruited to fight or work in the diamond fields. Some Guinean civilians who have fled into RUF-held areas to escape attacks in Guinea, or who have been abducted by RUF forces, have faced the same abuses at the hands of the RUF. In addition, thousands of Liberian civilians and Sierra Leonean refugees in Liberia have fled into Sierra Leone, many into RUF-held areas, to escape increased human rights abuses and intense fighting in northern Liberia since February 2001.

If they succeed in reaching safe areas after passing through Kono and Kailahun Districts, returning refugees are resettled in camps or integrated into temporary settlements within local communities. **It appears, however, that large numbers of returning Sierra Leonean refugees and Guinean and Liberian refugees remain in RUF-held areas. The RUF is reported to have prevented many people from leaving, in an attempt to encourage humanitarian agencies to provide assistance to civilians in the area, apparently in the belief that RUF combatants would also benefit.**

The UN Mission in Sierra Leone (UNAMSIL), the UN peace-keeping operation in Sierra Leone, UNHCR and humanitarian agencies have only recently obtained limited access to some RUF-held areas. The number of civilians in these areas and the nature of their needs are difficult to estimate but there are likely to be hundreds of thousands of civilians in need of urgent humanitarian assistance. On 12 June 2001, UNHCR announced that it had been able to evacuate 130 Guinean and Liberian refugees from Kailahun District and that the RUF was willing to allow other refugees to leave their areas of control. As they progressively deploy into RUF-held areas, UNAMSIL peace-keeping troops must also fulfil their mandate to protect civilians from further human rights abuses.

The human rights abuses and the general failure of refugee protection in Guinea have forced very large numbers of refugees to return to Sierra Leone. Many of the Sierra Leonean refugees interviewed by Amnesty International in March and